

Air-to-Air Combat

At the beginning of the war, North Vietnam had virtually no planes and no airforce. With Soviet and Chinese assistance, however, it quickly developed air defenses capable of challenging US air attacks.

◀◀ BEFORE

US and Soviet jet aircraft entered into aerial combat for the first time during the Korean War.

BATTLE OVER KOREA

The US F-86 Sabre and the Soviet MiG-15 went toe to toe in **aerial dogfights** during the **Korean War**. The United States also used **helicopters** in Korea, especially for search-and-rescue (SAR) of pilots downed behind enemy lines.

PREPARING FOR CONFLICT

In the early stages of the Vietnam War, before the **Tonkin Gulf Incident**, US Air Force pilots **trained South Vietnamese crews** to fly propeller-driven T-28 fighters. After US air raids on North Vietnam in August 1964, the People's Republic of **China** provided Hanoi with a small number of MiG-15 and MiG-17 fighter jets.

To defend against Operation Rolling Thunder, North Vietnam acquired more than 100 fighter jets from China and the Soviet Union, including the Russian high-performance MiG-21, which became North Vietnam's main interceptor. It also put in place an integrated air defense system, with early-warning radar and radar-directed anti-aircraft artillery (AAA). This accounted for about 80 percent of the US planes downed over North Vietnam. Although Soviet-supplied surface-to-air missiles (SAMs) struck their targets just 2 percent of the time, they were a threat to high-altitude missions, such as B-52 sorties.

North Vietnam's air defenses became extremely effective. Although US flights could bomb AAA and SAM sites and counter (but not eliminate) that part of North Vietnam's defenses, it could not destroy its fleet of MiGs other than through air-to-air combat. Hanoi stationed its MiGs at airfields in southern China, which was beyond the area of combat permitted by Washington.